Essay 2 (Version 2): Atticus Finch — *To Kill a Mockingbird* by Harper Lee

Atticus Finch is rarely examined as a flawed character — yet it is precisely his flaws that make him one of literature's most thought-provoking protagonists. Beneath his celebrated moral courage lies a dangerous optimism: an unshakeable belief that reason and law can overcome hatred. This internal conflict between his faith in human goodness and the brutal reality of Maycomb's racism does not merely colour the plot — it determines its tragic outcome.

Atticus's idealism is revealed most starkly in his instruction to Scout after she faces cruelty at school: *"You never really understand a person until you consider things from his point of view — until you climb into his skin and walk around in it"* (Chapter 3). This is Atticus's governing philosophy — empathy as a universal solution. It is admirable, but it is also naive. He applies this principle equally to reasonable men and to those whose prejudice is not a misunderstanding but a deliberate, structural choice. His internal conflict emerges from the gap between what he believes people are capable of and what Maycomb consistently proves they are willing to do.

This optimism drives him to take Tom Robinson's case with genuine belief that the courtroom can be a space of fairness. During the trial he delivers a passionate summation appealing to the jury's conscience: *"In the name of God, do your duty"* (Chapter 20). It is a powerful, rational appeal — and it fails completely. The jury convicts Tom Robinson despite overwhelming evidence of his innocence, exposing the limit of Atticus's worldview. His faith in institutions is the very thing that blinds him to how thoroughly those institutions have been corrupted by racial prejudice. The external plot — Tom's conviction, his desperate escape attempt, his death — flows directly from this miscalculation.

Maycomb's social structure sharpens Atticus's internal contradiction at every turn. The town operates on an unspoken but ironclad racial hierarchy, and Atticus's insistence on treating Tom Robinson as an equal human being is perceived not as decency but as betrayal. Miss Stephanie Crawford gossips, the Cunninghams withdraw their friendship, and his own sister Alexandra frets about family reputation. When Scout asks why he is defending Tom if he knows he cannot win, Atticus replies: *"Simply because we were licked a hundred years before we started is no reason for us not to try"* (Chapter 9). This reveals the central tension within him — he is simultaneously aware that the system is rigged and committed to working within it anyway. His flaw is not cowardice, but a refusal to acknowledge that moral argument alone cannot dismantle systemic injustice.

The consequences of this blind spot extend beyond the courtroom. By trusting that Bob Ewell's humiliation in court would dissipate harmlessly, Atticus leaves his children exposed. It is Boo Radley — a recluse who operates entirely outside Maycomb's social order — who ultimately saves Jem and Scout, not the law, not reason, and not Atticus himself. Scout's quiet realisation that *"Atticus was right. One time he said you never really understand a person until you climb into his skin"* (Chapter 31) carries a bittersweet irony: she has grown into her father's empathy, yet the world around her has not.

Was Atticus's fate inevitable? His personal integrity remains intact — but the outcome he worked toward was preventable only if Maycomb's community had possessed equal courage. His tragedy is not personal failure but institutional failure dressed in the clothing of individual defeat. Atticus could not save Tom Robinson because he fought a social war with a lawyer's tools. His fate reveals literature's most uncomfortable truth: that goodness, without power, is insufficient.